

W H A L E C L A S S

Circle Time Guide

Everything you need, one page per day

The Cycle of Plants

Week 13

Week of Nov 16–20

13 minutes a day

ages 2.5–6

English learners





Week 13 · Week Overview

The Cycle of Plants
Print · laminate · ring-bind · hold this all week

5 words they'll own by Friday →

seed

root

leaf

flower

fruit

Little's (2.5–3)

One word + a gesture is a win: **"Seed!"** (curl up tiny on the floor), **"Grow!"** (rise up slowly), **"Flower!"** (both hands bloom open above your head).

Bigs (4–6)

Sentence frames: **"I plant a seed."**

"The roots go down."

"The leaves go up."

"The flower is beautiful."

The week at a glance

MON	A Seed	a jar of seeds in the Magic Box
TUE	Roots Go Down	a whole small plant pulled up, roots rinsed clean under the tap so every hair shows, in the Ma...
WED	Leaves Go Up	one enormous leaf in the Magic Box
THU	The Flower Opens	one real flower in the Magic Box, still with its stem and a leaf on it; a second flower you ar...
FRI	Fruit & Seed Again + Big Review	an apple and a knife in the Magic Box, with every prop from the week underneath

2 MIN

Magic Box hook

4 MIN

Teach the words

3 MIN

Song · today's verse

3 MIN

Game · move it

1 MIN

Whisper-shout close

Weekly rituals — use these every single day

Attention grabber: Teacher: **"One, two, three — eyes on me!"** · Kids: **"One, two — eyes on you!"**

The Magic Box: any box with a lid. Chant it, shake it, sniff it, peek dramatically — the day's key prop lives inside.

The two-tier rule: never make a little produce a sentence, and never let a big get away with one word.

Whisper → shout close: calms them down, then releases them — every single closing.

Teacher-fails-on-purpose: once a day, get it wrong and let them correct you — the correction shout is the loudest language of the day.

One song a week: same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning, the whole song on Friday.

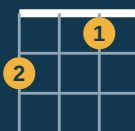
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G C E A

C

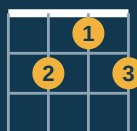
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G C E A

F

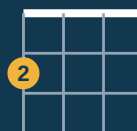
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G C E A

G7

0 0 0



G C E A

Am

Uke quick-ref

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up ("sing — song — sing-a"). Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the fun.

The song needs only **C · F · G7 · Am**.

MONDAY

A Seed

Today's words: **seed**

Grab: a **jar of seeds** in the Magic Box — one enormous broad bean and, beside it, a seed like a speck of dust (poppy, or the dust out of a lettuce packet); a tray of beans, pebbles and buttons all mixed together; the bean jar you started last Friday; the seed card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box gives a tiny dry *shhhh* when you tilt it, like sand. Whole class chants:

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Shake it — that whispery rattle again. Sniff it. Peek in, and look *disappointed*.

TEACHER "Oh... there's nothing in here. Just... a little **stone**." (*lift out the broad bean between two fingers, hold it up, and turn it slowly*)

Then, very quietly: "But this stone is **alive**. There is a whole **plant** asleep inside it."

Curl up tiny on the floor, all of you. "**Seed!**"

4 MIN TEACH · SEED

The big bean in one palm, the dust-speck seed on one fingertip. Both go round the circle, ten seconds each pair of hands:

This one is **BIG**. (*hold the broad bean up high*)

This one is so small I can hardly see it. (*peer at your fingertip, cross-eyed*)

But they are **both** seeds... (*hold them side by side*)

and they are both **fast asleep**. (*hands together against your cheek*)

LITTLES hold one seed and say the one word "**Seed!**" **BIGS** take the frame: "**I plant a seed.**" "**The seed is small.**"

Then bring out **Friday's bean jar** and put it in the middle of the circle. The bean has split; a fat white root is pushing down the glass. Nobody touches it. Say what you see and nothing more: "*Something came out. It went **down**.*" Then it goes on the shelf, and one child draws it in the growth book — the first of five drawings.

Teacher fails: try to plant the bean by putting it carefully on top of a **closed** jar lid. Pat it. Wait for the plant. Look at your watch. Wait.

Chinese moment: lay the **seed** card beside the jar. Then Li Shen's two lines, said slowly with your hands — **Plant one seed in spring, harvest ten thousand grains in autumn**. One seed in the spring (*one finger*), ten thousand seeds in the autumn (*both hands thrown wide*). That is the whole week in fourteen characters.

3 MIN GAME · SEED OR NOT A SEED?

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" The tray goes in the middle: broad beans, sunflower seeds, apple pips mixed up with pebbles, buttons and beads.

TEACHER "Take ONE. Look at it. Is it a **seed**... or **not a seed**?" (*two hoops or two cloths on the floor, one for each*)

One child at a time chooses an object and lays it in a hoop. **LITTLES** say the one word as it lands: "**Seed!**" or a head-shake. **BIGS** "**It is a seed. It can grow.**" "**It is not a seed.**"

Go round twice. Do **not** correct anybody out loud — a pebble in the seed hoop is Thursday's problem, and by then they will move it themselves.

The honest answer to "how do you know?" is "**we plant it and see.**" Keep one wrong guess back, plant it beside a bean in a pot, and let the week answer it for you.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody curled up tiny on the floor, one seed held in a closed fist. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Seed... root... leaf... flower... **FRUIT!**" (*grow all the way up through the line and throw both arms open on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Tiny Seed* (Eric Carle) — the whole week, in one book, on Monday. Read it again on Friday and they will tell you what happens next on every page.

♪ **TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · A LITTLE SEED** chorus → Monday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C A little seed down **F** in the **C** ground, (*crouch right down, curled up small*)

Am Rain and **C** sun **G7** all a **C** round! (*fingers rain down, then arms circle up*)

C Roots go down and **F** leaves go **C** up, (*point down, then stretch up*)

F A flower **C** opens **G7** like a **C** cup! (*hands cupped, then bloomed wide open*)

MONDAY · SEED

C A tiny seed, so small, so still, (*hold up one finger and freeze*)

G7 Plant it in the pot — **C** yes I will! (*press it into an imaginary pot*)

The one song of the week — same chorus at every circle, one new verse each morning. Start it **crouched on the floor** and stand all the way up through the chorus: by Friday the song is a plant growing, and they do it without being told. Chords on the Song tab.

TUESDAY

Roots Go Down

Today's words: **root** (*seed comes back every day*)

Grab: a whole small plant pulled up, roots rinsed clean under the tap so every hair shows, in the Magic Box on a white cloth; a carrot with its leaves still on; a glass of water; the bean jar; the root card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box is heavier and something inside it is **damp**. Chant, then shake — a soft wet thud, once.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Sniff it, properly, with your eyes shut. "It smells like... **rain**. It smells like the **ground**."

TEACHER "Somebody pulled a whole plant right OUT of the earth." (*lift it out by the stem so the roots hang down and swing, and hold it high*)

Point down at the floor with both hands. "**Root!**"

4 MIN TEACH · ROOT

Hold the plant up by the stem so it hangs the right way up, and go bottom to top, one beat each:

Down here — the **roots**. (*run one finger down the hanging roots*)

They hold on **tight** so the wind can't take it. (*grip your own two fists together and pull*)

And they **drink**. (*a long, loud slurp*)

Up, up, up the stem... all the way to the **leaves**. (*finger travelling up*)

The plant goes round the circle. Everybody touches the roots — they are wet, and stringy, and slightly horrible, and that is the point.

LITTLES point at the floor and say "**Root!**" **BIGS** "**The roots go down.**" "**The roots drink the water.**"

Then the carrot. Hold it up and wait. "*What if I told you this whole thing IS a root?*" Snap it in half. Let that sit.

Teacher fails: hold the plant **upside down**, roots waving in the air, leaves buried in your other hand, and admire it. "What a beautiful plant." Wait.

Chinese moment: the **root** card goes down beside yesterday's seed. Point at the plant, then the card, then the floor. Then eat the carrot. radish is a root — and so is sweet potato, and potato is not, but nobody needs that today.

3 MIN GAME · I AM A TREE

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Everybody stands, well spread out, plenty of room between them.

TEACHER "Your feet are the **roots**. Push them into the floor. Your body is the **stem**. Your arms are the **leaves**."

Then you are the wind. Blow gently — only the leaves move. Blow harder — the stem sways. Blow a **storm** — everything moves except the feet. "**My roots are holding ON!**"

LITTLES just wave their arms and keep their feet stuck. **BIGS** get the whole sentence: "**My roots hold me down.**"

Last round: one child is the wind and you are a tree. Fall over, dramatically, when they blow. Feet off the floor. They will tell you exactly what you did wrong.

Feet **stuck to the floor** is the whole rule of this game, and it is also the only way twenty children storm about the room without a collision.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody standing, feet planted, pushing down hard. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Root... root... **ROOT!**" (*push both hands down to the floor and stamp once on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Jack and the Beanstalk* — told, not read, with one real bean in your hand. Plant it in front of them at the end and refuse to promise anything.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · A LITTLE SEED chorus → Tuesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C A little seed down **F** in the **C** ground, (*crouch right down, curled up small*)

Am Rain and **C** sun **G7** all a **C** round! (*fingers rain down, then arms circle up*)

C Roots go down and **F** leaves go **C** up, (*point down, then stretch up*)

F A flower **C** opens **G7** like a **C** cup! (*hands cupped, then bloomed wide open*)

TUESDAY · ROOT

C Roots go down, down, down below, (*push both hands down, lower each time*)

G7 Drinking, drinking — **C** that's how I grow! (*slurp, then stretch up tall*)

Sing "down, down, down" lower each time — drop your voice a step on each one until the last is a growl. They will copy the pitch before they copy the word, and that is real listening work.

WEDNESDAY

Leaves Go Up

Today's words: **leaf** (*seed · root come back*)

Grab: one **enormous leaf** in the Magic Box — a ginkgo or a plane leaf off a Beijing pavement, the biggest you can find; a basket for the leaf hunt; paper and fat crayons for rubbings; the bean jar; the leaf card. Coats on — today you go outside.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box is light again, and it **crackles**. Chant, then shake it slowly next to your ear.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Open the lid a crack, look in, and shut it fast. Do it again. Then open it right up and lift out the leaf with two hands, like it is made of glass.

TEACHER "Look how **BIG**. Bigger than my hand..." (*hold it flat against your own palm, then against a child's face — bigger than that too*)

Both arms stretched up and open. "**Leaf!**"

4 MIN TEACH · LEAF

Hold the leaf up to the window so the light comes through it. Everybody leans in:

Look — little **lines**, all over it. (*trace one vein with a fingertip*)

That is the **drink** coming up from the roots. (*finger travelling up from the stalk*)

And the leaf holds it up to the **sun**... (*leaf flat on your open palm, lifted to the light*)

...and that is how the plant makes its **food**. (*rub your tummy*)

LITTLES reach both arms up and say "**Leaf!**" **BIGS** "**The leaves go up.**" "**The leaf catches the sun.**"

Then lay the three things you have collected in a row on the mat: the **seed**, the plant with its **roots**, the **leaf**. Point along the row and say the three words. That row grows by one every day until Friday.

Teacher fails: hold the leaf up to the **ceiling light** with enormous seriousness and announce that this plant will now grow very fast. Hold it there. Wait for somebody to point at the window.

Chinese moment: the **leaf** card joins the row — seed · root · leaf. Then show them ginkgo and let them say it; ginkgo leaves are all over Beijing in November and they will find them on the way home.

3 MIN GAME · LEAF HUNT

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Coats on, basket out, everybody outside. One rule, said before you open the door:

TEACHER "Bring me **ONE** leaf. Just one. The one *you* like best."

Back inside, all the leaves go on the floor in one long line: **biggest to smallest**. The children build the line; you sit on your hands.

LITTLES bring their leaf and name it: "**Leaf!**" **BIGS** compare: "**Mine is bigger than yours.**" "**This one is the smallest.**"

Then crayon rubbings, one each, at the table — leaf under the paper, crayon flat on its side. The lines come up out of nowhere and it is properly magic.

A child who brings back six leaves has not broken the rule, they have found a **gradation exercise**. Line all six up smallest to biggest and say so.

1 MIN CLOSE

Everybody standing, arms stretched right up, leaf in one hand. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Leaf... leaf... LEAF!" (*wave both arms overhead like a tree in wind on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Leaf Man* (Lois Ehlert) — then make one on the table out of this morning's hunt. It will not survive till home time. That is fine.

» TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · A LITTLE SEED chorus → Wednesday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C A little seed down **F** in the **C** ground, (*crouch right down, curled up small*)

Am Rain and **C** sun **G7** all a **C** round! (*fingers rain down, then arms circle up*)

C Roots go down and **F** leaves go **C** up, (*point down, then stretch up*)

F A flower **C** opens **G7** like a **C** cup! (*hands cupped, then bloomed wide open*)

WEDNESDAY · LEAF

C Green, green leaves that catch the sun, (*both hands flat, tilted up to the light*)

G7 One, two, three — **C** look, more than one! (*count three, then wiggle all ten*)

Sing this one **outside** if the leaf hunt runs long — standing under a real tree, counting real leaves. It is the same three minutes and they remember it for a year.

THURSDAY

The Flower Opens

Today's words: **flower** (seed · root · leaf come back)

Grab: one **real flower** in the Magic Box, still with its stem and a leaf on it; a second flower you are willing to pull to pieces; a magnifying glass; the bean jar (it will have a leaf by now); the flower card.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

Today the box makes no sound at all. Chant, shake it — nothing. Shake it harder — still nothing.

EVERYONE "What's in the box? What's in the box?"

Then **sniff** it. Sniff it again. Let your whole face change. Pass the closed box round and let every single child sniff the lid before anybody sees inside.

TEACHER "Something in here **smells**. And it has been waiting all week..." (*lift the flower out slowly, stem first, so it appears the way it grows*)

Both hands blooming open from a closed cup. **"Flower!"**

4 MIN TEACH · FLOWER

The flower stands in a glass in the middle. Everybody's hands make one too, and open with the words:

First the seed... (*fists tight, tucked in low*)

then the **root**, then the **leaf**... (*point down, then stretch up*)

and right at the top, at the very end... (*hands closed into a cup and lifted*)

the **FLOWER**. (*open both hands wide, slowly, like a time-lapse*)

LITTLES bloom their hands and say **"Flower!"** **BIGS** **"The flower is beautiful."** **"The flower smells nice."**

Then take the second flower apart on a white cloth, one piece at a time, naming almost nothing: petal ... petal ... petal ... and this dusty yellow bit in the middle. Magnifying glass. Get a fingertip yellow. *"Bees carry this from flower to flower — and THAT is how a flower turns into a fruit."* One sentence, then stop.

Teacher fails: hold the flower by its head and try to plant the **petals**, one by one, in the pot. Pat the soil down. Look pleased. Wait.

Chinese moment: the **flower** card joins the row — seed · root · leaf · flower. Say one flower, then count the flowers in the room together: one flower, two flowers, three flowers. flower is the measure word and they pick it up in a week.

3 MIN GAME · THE FLOWER OPENS

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Everybody curled up on the floor in a tight little ball, hands over their heads. You are the sun and the rain.

TEACHER "Here comes the rain... here comes the sun... now **open**. As slowly as you can. The slowest flower **wins**."

Count them up, one number every two seconds, all the way to ten. On ten everybody must be standing with both hands wide open, and then — **freeze**. Nobody moves. Walk round and admire the garden out loud.

LITTLES just have to get up and open their hands. **BIGS** narrate as they go: **"I am growing."** **"Now I am a flower!"**

Second round, backwards: winter comes, and the slowest flower to close up small again wins that one too.

This is the calmest three minutes of the week — **use it before a transition**, not after one. Slow is the skill being practised here, not speed.

1 MIN CLOSE

Hands cupped shut at chest height, ready to bloom. Whisper → normal → shout:

EVERYONE "Flower... flower... FLOWER!" (*both hands burst open above the head on the shout*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *Planting a Rainbow* (Lois Ehlert) — every page is one colour of flower. They will start calling the colours out for you.

▶ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · A LITTLE SEED chorus → Thursday's verse → chorus

CHORUS

C A little seed down **F** in the **C** ground, (*crouch right down, curled up small*)

Am Rain and **C** sun **G7** all a **C** round! (*fingers rain down, then arms circle up*)

C Roots go down and **F** leaves go **C** up, (*point down, then stretch up*)

F A flower **C** opens **G7** like a **C** cup! (*hands cupped, then bloomed wide open*)

THURSDAY · FLOWER

C A flower, a flower, pink and red, (*one hand blooms, then the other*)

G7 It opens up **C** above my head! (*both hands wide open overhead*)

Hold the last "head" for four whole beats with your hands wide open above you and do not move. The class will hold it with you, and twenty children standing dead still with their hands in the air is the best moment of the week.

FRIDAY

Fruit & Seed Again + Big Review

Today's words: **seed · root · leaf · flower · fruit** — the whole week

Grab: an **apple** and a knife in the Magic Box, with every prop from the week underneath — the seed jar, the pulled-up plant, the big leaf, the flower; a plate; the bean jar (now a real plant); the awards (print pack page 17); the fruit card.
Sunday is **Minor Snow**.

2 MIN MAGIC BOX HOOK

The box comes out fat and bulging and will not quite shut.

TEACHER "Today the box is **FULL** — it's got our whole **WEEK** inside it!"

Pull each prop out and hold it up in complete silence. They will supply the word before you can.

The jar of seeds → "**Seed!**" The pulled-up plant → "**Root!**" The big leaf → "**Leaf!**" Yesterday's flower → "**Flower!**"

Last of all, one apple. Hold it up. Nobody knows what it is doing here. Hands ready... "**FRUIT!**"

4 MIN TEACH · FRUIT, THEN THE WHOLE WEEK

Everybody watches while you cut the apple **across the middle**, not down — and open it like a book. There is a star inside, and the star is full of pips.

A flower turned into this **fruit**. (*hold the two halves up*)

And inside the fruit... (*turn one half round very slowly*)

...there is a **star**. (*let them see it, and wait*)

And in the star — a **SEED**. (*pick one pip out and hold it up between two fingers*)

Then everybody stands and the whole week goes through the body, twice, slow then fast: **seed** (curled up tiny) → **root** (push down) → **leaf** (stretch up) → **flower** (bloom) → **fruit** (round arms) → and back to **seed**.

LITTLES do the five gestures and shout the five words. **BIGS** owe you a sentence each: "**I plant a seed.**" "**The roots go down.**" "**The flower is beautiful.**" "**The fruit has seeds inside.**"

Teacher fails: hold up the pip and say "well, that's the end of the story then." Put it in the bin. Wait. Somebody will physically stop you.

Chinese moment: the **fruit** card completes the row — seed · root · leaf · flower · fruit, the whole week on the mat, and you can read it left to right like a sentence. Then: Sunday is **Minor Snow**, the day the first snow can come. at Minor Snow we pickle the vegetables — this is when families put the vegetables away for winter. Everything we planted, we keep.

3 MIN GAME · SEED TO SEED

"One, two, three — eyes on me!" Five children stand up and take one stage each: **seed · root · leaf · flower · fruit**. The rest of the circle is the sun, the rain and the wind.

TEACHER "Seed — you're first. Curl up. Now... who comes next?"

Each child does their stage in order, holding the pose, until all five are standing in a line and the whole plant is built out of children. Then the fruit child holds out one hand with a pip in it — and the **seed** child takes it and curls up again. The circle claps once. It goes round.

LITTLES are the sun and the rain, which is a real job with real actions. **BIGS** do the five stages and narrate: "**Now I am the flower.**"

Run it three times with new children each time, and get faster.

The pip changing hands is the whole idea of the week. Do not explain it. Do it three times, and by the third round they will start shouting "again!" before the fruit child has even moved.

1 MIN CLOSE + AWARDS

Every child gets a "You are a STAR!" award to take home with the Minor Snow news — and one real seed in a twist of paper to plant at home. Then, standing round the bean jar, all five gestures:

EVERYONE "Seed... root... leaf... flower... **FRUIT!**" (*all the way up from the floor, then everybody drops back down to a seed on the last beat*)

Got 3 spare minutes? *The Tiny Seed* (Eric Carle) again — on Monday you read it to them; today they read it to you, holding the bean jar.

♪ TODAY'S SONG MOMENT · A LITTLE SEED Friday's verse, then the WHOLE song, top to bottom

CHORUS

C A little seed down **F** in the **C** ground, (*crouch right down, curled up small*)

Am Rain and **C** sun **G7** all a **C** round! (*fingers rain down, then arms circle up*)

C Roots go down and **F** leaves go **C** up, (*point down, then stretch up*)

F A flower **C** opens **G7** like a **C** cup! (*hands cupped, then bloomed wide open*)

FRIDAY · FRUIT

C Cut the apple — what do I see? (*open two cupped hands*)

G7 A little seed — **C** ready for me! (*one finger up, then curl back down small*)

The finale: chorus → Monday, Tuesday, Wednesday, Thursday, Friday → chorus, standing round the bean jar. Start crouched on the floor and grow through the whole thing. On the very last word everybody drops back down into a seed — because it starts again. This run-through is the review of the entire week.

★ A Little Seed

Week 13 theme song
C (0003) · F (2010) · G7 (0212) · Am (2000)

The one song of the week — sung at every circle. Same chorus daily, one new verse each morning, full song on Friday.

CHORUS — SING IT EVERY SINGLE DAY

- C** A little seed down **F** in the **C** ground, *(crouch right down, curled up small)*
Am Rain and **C** sun **G7** all a **C** round! *(fingers rain down, then arms circle up)*
C Roots go down and **F** leaves go **C** up, *(point down, then stretch up)*
F A flower **C** opens **G7** like a **C** cup! *(hands cupped, then bloomed wide open)*

MONDAY · SEED

- C** A tiny seed, so small, so still, *(hold up one finger and freeze)*
G7 Plant it in the pot — **C** yes I will! *(press it into an imaginary pot)*

TUESDAY · ROOT

- C** Roots go down, down, down below, *(push both hands down, lower each time)*
G7 Drinking, drinking — **C** that's how I grow! *(slurp, then stretch up tall)*

WEDNESDAY · LEAF

- C** Green, green leaves that catch the sun, *(both hands flat, tilted up to the light)*
G7 One, two, three — **C** look, more than one! *(count three, then wiggle all ten)*

THURSDAY · FLOWER

- C** A flower, a flower, pink and red, *(one hand blooms, then the other)*
G7 It opens up **C** above my head! *(both hands wide open overhead)*

FRIDAY · FRUIT

- C** Cut the apple — what do I see? *(open two cupped hands)*
G7 A little seed — **C** ready for me! *(one finger up, then curl back down small)*

Strum: Down · Down · Down-Up (“sing — song — sing-a”).

Can't manage it yet? Four slow downs per bar works fine — the kids only hear the fun.

Practice this loop for five minutes tonight: **C** (4 strums) → **F** (4 strums) → **C** → **G7** → **C**. That is most of the chorus. Add **Am** last — it is one finger on the same string as F, so slide **Am** → **F** → **Am** until it stops feeling like a change; you only need it for two words, “Rain and sun”. If your fingers get stuck, put the uke down and do the finger-play instead: the class will not notice, and the actions carry the meaning either way.